

The Limits of Panethnicity: A Framework for Understanding Latinx Ethnoracial Identities

Chris Flores*

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Abstract

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*PhD Candidate in Political Science, Stanford University. Direct correspondence to: Chris Flores, floresc@stanford.edu, 305-987-9728. 616 Jane Stanford Way, Encina Hall West, Room 100, Stanford, CA 94305

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Abstract

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Introduction

How do Latinos identify their race, and why?¹ Existing scholarship approaches these questions from two related perspectives. On the one hand, scholars contend that panethnicity or national origin are the primary lens through which Latinos understand their race (Hitlin, Brown, and Elder 2007; Roth 2012). From this perspective, Latinos' responses to a Census race question – most often White, “Some other race,” or both – reflect imposed categorization schemes rather than lived experiences or self-understandings (Dowling 2015). Experiences with discrimination and racialization by others as Latinx produce panethnic

ethnoracial identities, and mobilization in response to hostile immigration environments continuously constructs and reinforces Latinx identity (Golash-Boza 2006; Jiménez 2008). In Latin America, historical narratives around racial mixture (*mestizaje*) fostered strong national identities despite ethnoracial differences (Hooker 2014; Telles and Flores 2013).

On the other hand, a second perspective suggests that racial differentiation within the Latinx population can produce distinct ethnoracial identities (Telles 2018). Some scholars argue that lighter-skinned Latinos may be incorporated into whiteness (Frank, Akresh, and Lu 2010; Bonilla-Silva 2004; cf. Vargas 2015), while qualitative studies highlight the distinct, often overlooked experiences of groups like Indigenous Mexicans and Afro-Latinos (Aja 2016; Boj Lopez 2017; Fox and Rivera-Salgado 2004; Hordge-Freeman and Veras 2020). Race and color continue to structure socioeconomic outcomes both in Latin America and among U.S. Latinos (Dávila, Mora, and Stockly 2011; Telles 2014; Villarreal 2014). Although *mestizaje* ideologies remain prevalent, categories like whiteness, Blackness, and Indigeneity are increasingly salient in Latin America (Paschel 2016; Flores, Vignau Loría, and Martínez Casas 2023). These shifts may, in turn, shape how Latinos conceptualize their ethnoracial identities in the U.S. (Roth 2012).

At present, however, we lack a comprehensive account of what explains this variation in Latinos' racial self-understandings. Due to data limitations, we are unable to assess how Latinos identify on their own terms. Existing quantitative research relies largely on closed-ended self-classification – an important institutional process but one which imperfectly reflects individuals' open-ended identities (Roth 2016) – while qualitative work focuses on specific national origin subgroups. In light of these limitations, the social processes that underlie how and why Latinos adopt ethnoracial labels like Afro-Latino, white, or mixed race merit further attention. Latinos exert agency over ethnoracial boundaries through their identities (Brown and Jones 2015; Mora 2014). As Latinos make up one in five people in the U.S. and are the largest ethnoracial group in California and Texas, clarifying the

processes underlying Latinos' ethnoracial identities helps us understand the construction of ethnoracial boundaries in the U.S. more broadly.

I develop a framework that bridges these two views – recognizing the overarching racialization of Latinidad on the one hand and substantial intra-Latinx ethnoracial difference on the other – and highlights the complexity and range of identities for individuals within the panethnic category. Synthesizing the literatures on social identities, ethnoracial boundaries, and racial fluidity in the Americas, I theorize the conditions under which Latinos adopt an ethnoracial identity primarily through the lens of panethnicity or national origin or, alternatively, identify with additional ethnoracial categories. I employ a novel empirical approach across three surveys (N=733, N=1,488, and N=577), combining open-ended identity items with social psychological measures of identity centrality (Croll and Gerteis 2019; Davenport, Iyengar, and Westwood 2022; McClain et al. 2009). Compared to self-classification questions, this approach captures overlapping ethnoracial identities without equating them with multiracial identification or assuming they are of equal importance to the self.

While a majority of sampled Latinx respondents understand their ethnoracial identities in panethnic or national origin terms, a third identify their race beyond panethnicity, with labels such as Afro-Latino, Indigenous, white, or mixed race. A third of respondents also rank these labels as more important to their identity than being Latinx, particularly so among Afro-Latinx self-classifiers. To understand the ethnoracial identity decisions of Latinos, I employ the machine-learning method of random forests (Montgomery and Olivella 2018). The random forests reveal that racialization by others and immigrant generation are key predictors of this choice, while socioeconomic status and national origin are not. In-depth interviews (N=29) explore plausible mechanisms. Whereas higher SES influences the adoption of a strong singular Latinx identity for some, for others it informs the importance of identities like Afro-Latinx. National origin's influence may be channeled

through immigrant generation, explaining its weak predictive power among non-Mexicans.

This work makes several contributions to the literatures on ethnoracial identities and boundary formation. First, it develops a conceptual framework that foregrounds variation in Latinos' ethnoracial self-understandings and empirically tests it with original survey measures, machine-learning methods, and in-depth interviews. These findings suggest that many Latinos may be blurring ethnoracial boundaries such that Latinidad is understood to be overlapping with – rather than mutually exclusive from – other ethnoracial categories like Black, white, or Indigenous. Second, the random forests elucidate a nonlinear relationship between immigrant generation and ethnoracial identity decisions. First and third-plus generation Latinos are the most likely to adopt additional ethnoracial identities, which suggests both that proximity to Latin American ethnoracial schemas and distance from immigration increase the likelihood of identifying beyond panethnicity. Finally, this work builds upon a substantial body of comparative work in Latin America on national ethnoracial schemas and socioeconomic status by clarifying how these processes operate for Latinos in the U.S.

Ethnoracial Identities across the Americas

Ethnoracial schemas, or conceptualizations of ethnoracial boundaries and how individuals fit within them, vary widely across the Americas. Latinos either immigrate with or inherit these distinct ethnoracial schemas, which interact with U.S. understandings of race (Roth 2012; Zamora 2022). I treat race (or “ethnorace”) as a subset of ethnicity – broader practices of categorizing humans through descent – based in particular on phenotypes and human bodies (Chandra 2006; Wimmer 2008). However, I center race in this analysis due to its emergence from enslavement and colonization and its importance in determining social relations in the Americas (Omi and Winant 1994; Saperstein, Penner, and Light 2013). Departing from “folk” approaches that separate Latinidad as an ethnicity and not a race, I

treat Latinidad as an ethnoracial category assumed to share a set of physical characteristics (Feliciano 2016) and one which emerged from the exchange between state ascription and self-identification (Brown and Jones 2015). Panethnicity is a consolidated ethnic group that maintains subethnic distinctions (Okamoto and Mora 2014), so I refer to “national origin” as the subethnic groups (e.g., Mexicans, Cubans) within Latinidad.

Similar to the U.S., Latin American ethnoracial relations are rooted in the enslavement of African and Indigenous peoples, colonization, and immigration (Davenport 2020; Telles 2014; Wade 2010). However, Latin America historically lacked legal segregation and had a much higher degree of race-mixing than the U.S., promoted by elites in the 20th century to foster national unity, erase Black and Indigenous people, and resist growing U.S. imperialism (Hooker 2014; Telles 2014). As a result, mestizaje ideologies are central to the national identities of Latin American countries today and to many individuals’ ethnoracial identities (Landale and Oropesa 2002; Telles and Paschel 2014). Nonetheless, countries in the region continue to be arranged hierarchically by race (Monk 2016; Telles 2014). Ethnoracial categories – though they may have fuzzier boundaries than in the U.S. – continue to hold significant meaning and power even in spite of dominant colorblind mestizaje ideologies (Sue 2013), and Black and Indigenous activism has led to growing recognition of ethnoracial inequalities and increased the salience of Black and Indigenous identities (Flores et al. 2023; Paschel 2016; Telles and Torche 2019). Latinx immigrants and their descendants may possess an awareness of the privileges of light skin in their countries of origin and globally, though who is accepted as white varies across borders (Wimmer 2008).

In the U.S., Latinos have historically occupied a blurry position between white and Black people, being simultaneously considered white in some contexts and nonwhite in others (Fox and Guglielmo 2012; Gómez 2007; Telles and Ortiz 2008). Mexican activists and elites often countered discrimination by asserting their legal whiteness and distancing themselves from Black people (Haney López 2003; Gómez 2007).² At the same time,

Mexican Americans were subject to segregation, intense discrimination, and violence such as lynchings (Telles and Ortiz 2008). During the civil rights movement, activist strategies shifted; the growing Chicano movement and the Young Lords resisted whiteness and engaged in coalition building with Black people (Fernández 2020; Haney López 2003). These activist groups came together with Cubans to advocate for representation, and in 1980, the Census began counting Latinos as a category. Until the 1970s, Mexicans, Cubans, and Puerto Ricans did not see themselves as belonging to a broader panethnic group, but the dialectical exchange between institutions, activists, and ethnic entrepreneurs changed this (Mora 2014).

Today, scholarship points to three possible patterns of ethnoracial identities for Latinos. For many, racialization and discrimination reinforce panethnic or national origin identities (Golash-Boza 2006; Jiménez 2008). Work on ethnic attrition demonstrates that others – particularly those with lighter skin or with an Anglo white parent – may shed Latinx ties and assimilate into the white middle-class mainstream (Duncan and Trejo 2011). A third possibility, however, is that Latinos may retain strong panethnic or national origin ties while simultaneously understanding their race in more complex terms (Croll and Gerteis 2019). This possibility aligns with the experiences of many Black and Indigenous Latinos, who navigate racialization as Latinx in the U.S. while identifying as Black or Indigenous (Boj Lopez 2017; Fox and Rivera-Salgado 2004; Hordge-Freeman and Veras 2020). Many Latinos recognize the benefits to whiteness alongside holding Latinx identities (Haney López 2003), and white identity among Latinos predicts Republican partisanship and opposition to welfare (Filindra and Kolbe 2022). Thus, a complete understanding of Latinos' ethnoracial identities in the U.S. must account for these distinct possibilities.

Theory and Hypotheses

Following social identity theory (Tajfel and Turner 1986), I define ethnoracial identity as the subjective sense of self that an individual attaches to their perceived ethnoracial categories. In contrast to ethnoracial self-classification – the labels or boxes selected on closed-ended survey questions – ethnoracial identity is one’s public expression of race on their own terms. I use “identity” and “identification” to refer to this process, though one’s public identity may differ from their private, internal sense of self (Davenport 2016; Roth 2016). I argue that Latinos pursue one of two primary modes in identifying their race: a singular ethnoracial identity in panethnic or national origin terms (e.g., Latino, Mexican, Puerto Rican), or dual ethnoracial identities as both Latinx and as belonging to another ethnoracial category (e.g., white and Latino, Afro-Latinx). A third mode, involving panethnic attrition and the adoption of a singular non-Latinx ethnoracial identity (e.g., only white), is possible for later-generation Latinos and those with non-Latinx parentage. However, as panethnicity continues to be salient even for many later-generation Latinos with weaker cultural or immigrant ties (Telles and Ortiz 2008), I focus on the first two modes.

Instead of probing which specific self-classifications Latinos select from a set of options (e.g., “White,” “Some other race,” etc.), the framework discerns whether Latinos understand themselves primarily through the lens of panethnicity or recognize additional identities like Black, Indigenous, etc. That is, the framework shifts our attention from which particular labels Latinos select to the broader schemas through which they conceptualize their ethnoracial identities. I subsequently typologize panethnic and subethnic national origin identities within the same broader mode because they both represent a middle category vis-à-vis the dominant Black-white binary. While asserting a national origin identity may denote a distinct claim to racially differentiate oneself from broader Latinidad, such identities exist in contrast to ones that recognize subnational origin differences (e.g., Mexican vs. Afro-Mexican). Through transnational processes like immigration, panethnic

identities take on similar meaning in Latin America, even if secondary to national origin identities (Zamora 2022).

My framework centers the multidimensionality of ethnoracial identities, though measurements at a given point in time may not capture the full range of an individual's identities. Ethnoracial identities can change over time, and some identities may be more or less salient depending on social context (Davenport 2020). For example, an individual who identifies as Black, Latinx, and Afro-Latinx may sometimes identify only as Latinx when asked about their racial identity. Certain measures of race at a point in time may not capture all of these identities, but – when successfully elicited – Latinos' identities beyond panethnicity are consequential for intergroup relations, politics, and ethnoracial boundaries (Filindra and Kolbe 2022; Cleland and Gutierrez 2025).

Below, I develop theoretical expectations for how racialization, socioeconomic status, immigration, and national origin shape selection of these two primary identity modes.

Racialization

Ascriptive racialization by others – one's experience navigating the world being perceived as belonging to a given ethnoracial category – is a key constraint of ethnoracial identity (Irizarry et al. 2022; Omi and Winant 1994; Telles and Paschel 2014). Individuals may adopt ethnoracial identities that differ from how others perceive them, as with Afro-Latinos or Afro-Caribbeans who eschew Black identification or light-skinned Latinos perceived as white who hold strong Latinx identities (Roth 2016; Waters 1999). However, individuals who possess the prototypical features that are assumed to define Latinidad, like brown skin and straight black hair (Cobas, Duany, and Feagin 2009; Feliciano 2016), should be most likely to be racialized by others as Latinx, and subsequently adopt a singular ethnoracial identity rather than dual identities.

H1: Latinos who are racialized by others as Latinx will be more likely to adopt a

singular ethnoracial identity as Latinx and less likely to adopt dual ethnoracial identities.

Socioeconomic Status

The relationship between socioeconomic status and ethnoracial identity choices is complex. While much work in the Americas has focused on the whitening effect of higher socioeconomic status, more recent work nuances this finding. Higher SES may sometimes whiten self-classification (Saperstein and Penner 2012; Schwartzman 2007) and sometimes darken or polarize, increasing both white and Black self-classification (Telles and Paschel 2014). Further, Davenport (2016) draws a distinction between income and education; whereas higher income whitens self-classification among biracial students, higher parental education often increases nonwhite self-classification. This body of work suggests that higher SES – both education and income – should predict a greater likelihood of holding dual ethnoracial identities among Latinos, either by promoting white identification alongside Latinidad or by increasing awareness of one’s distinct racial heritage, as Black, Indigenous, etc.:

H2a: Latinos with a higher SES will be more likely to hold dual ethnoracial identities rather than singular ethnoracial identities.

Conversely, higher SES may have the opposite effect for two reasons. First, more formally educated Latinos may be more aware of the racialization faced by Latinos in the U.S. and activism in response to it, thereby rejecting other ethnoracial identities and maintaining a strong singular identity as Latinx (Roth 2012). Second, instead of higher SES whitening or darkening identification among Latinos, asserting a singular Latinx ethnoracial identity may itself be a form of upward ethnoracial mobility. For example, the children of higher SES Black Caribbean immigrants tend to identify as Caribbean more so than those of lower SES immigrants, who more often identify as Black (Waters 1999). This leads to a contrast-

ing expectation:

H2b: Latinos with a higher SES will be *less* likely to hold dual ethnoracial identities rather than singular ethnoracial identities.

Immigration and National Origin

Immigrant generation can affect ethnoracial identities through exposure to distinct ethnoracial schemas and closeness to cultural elements of Latinidad. Much of the work on immigration and Latinx identities focuses on Latinx immigrants (Frank et al. 2010; Roth 2012) or examines the choice between panethnic, national origin, or American labels (Golash-Boza 2006; Jones-Correa and Leal 1996). However, distance from the immigration experience may predict the adoption of dual ethnoracial identities through familiarity with U.S. racial categories, detachment from mestizaje ideologies, and weaker cultural ties (Irizarry et al. 2022; Sanchez and Masuoka 2010). First-generation Latinos may not only possess stronger cultural ties but also be racialized distinctly as Latinx upon coming to the U.S., leading to the following prediction:

H3a: Later-generation Latinos will be more likely to adopt dual ethnoracial identities than singular ethnoracial identities.

Alternatively, earlier-generation Latinos – who come from distinct countries where racial differences may be salient, and increasingly so over the past few decades – may be more likely to conceptualize themselves with dual ethnoracial identities. Growing up outside the U.S. may expose one to intra-Latinx ethnoracial hierarchies, discrimination, or Black and Indigenous movements. Earlier-generation individuals may, in turn, seek to maintain these distinct identities in light of cross-cutting racialization as Latinx. Meanwhile, later-generation individuals – in the face of persistent racialization (Jiménez 2008) – may identify primarily as Latinx and eschew other identities:

H3b: Later-generation Latinos will be *less* likely to adopt dual ethnoracial

identities than singular ethnoracial identities.

Finally, while *mestizaje* ideologies are prevalent throughout Latin America, conceptualizations of race vary widely by country (Telles and Flores 2013; Telles and Paschel 2014). I expect Caribbean Latinos – such as Puerto Ricans and Cubans – to be more likely to hold dual ethnoracial identities through the recognition and salience of various identities like Black, white, or mixed race. For Mexicans, given their historical racialization and the construction of Mexican identity through *mestizaje* (Dowling 2015), singular panethnic identities should be more prevalent. Because identifying as Spanish may represent a racialized claim to distinguish oneself from other Latinos (Salgado 2020), I expect respondents reporting ancestry in Spain to be more likely to adopt dual ethnoracial identities.

H4: Latinos with Mexican ancestry should be less likely to adopt dual ethnoracial identities, while Cubans, Puerto Ricans, and Latinos reporting ancestry in Spain should be more likely to do so.

Data and Methods

I draw upon several data sources that bridge qualitative and quantitative approaches to identity. First, I conducted three online surveys of Latinos through the Cint and Cloud Research Connect panel aggregators in June/July 2023 (N=733), April 2024 (N=1,488), and March 2026 (N=577). The first survey focused on assessing Latinos' open-ended sense of identity, while the second employed closed-ended measures of identity salience. The third survey replicates key findings from the first two and assesses the robustness of the primary measures of identity.³ The primary population of interest is self-identifying Latinos residing in the U.S.⁴

The samples are diverse across age, national origin, geographic location, and gender but overrepresent English-dominant, later generation, and college-educated Latinos, as

well as Latinos with a non-Latinx parent. The first survey was fielded only in English, while 9 percent of respondents took the second survey in Spanish.⁵ To account for these imbalances, I employ entropy weights matched to the Current Population Survey (Hainmueller 2012). Appendix A confirms that the weights improve imbalances by education, language, immigrant generation, and Latinx parentage. Even with weighting, however, descriptive results should be taken only as suggestive evidence of the framework and not as population-level distributions (MacInnis et al. 2018; Jerit and Barabas 2023).⁶

The final data source draws from 29 semi-structured in-depth interviews conducted from May 2023 to June 2025. Invitations were circulated through personal networks, email lists, and at the end of the first Cint survey. Interviews usually lasted 60-75 minutes and were conducted online or in person in the Bay Area. They are diverse across age, gender, national origin, region, and socioeconomic status; four interviews were conducted in Spanish, with the remainder in English. Because Latinos with a non-Latinx parent may be likely to recognize their parents' two distinct ethnoracial backgrounds (Davenport 2016, 2018), I purposely oversample on individuals with two Latinx parents to elucidate the meanings of dual ethnoracial identities for these individuals. The goal of my mixed methods approach is triangulation or confirmation (Small 2011). Interviews illuminate the meanings behind racial labels in greater depth than survey questions, and they shed light on the precise mechanisms by which SES or processes like racialization relate to individuals' identities.

Measuring Latinos' Ethnoracial Identities

To assess how Latinos identify their race in their own words, respondents in the first survey (N=733) received one of two versions of an open-ended racial identity question: "How do you racially identify? Please list a few things that come to mind for you" and "How would you identify your race to other [Hispanic or Latino] people? Please list a few things that come to mind for you."⁷ I included the prompt to encourage complexity and capture a greater range of identities, given that reporting one's race is a common practice for which

respondents may typically expect to give short, one-word answers.⁸ I subsequently coded responses as mentioning panethnicity, national origin, other racial groups or labels, being American, something else (e.g., cultural mentions or non-ethnoracial attributes), or as non-response. Using these codes, I map responses onto the identity framework to assess the prevalence of singular and dual ethnoracial identities: those who understand themselves primarily in panethnic or national origin terms, those who understand themselves with other racial labels (either with or without mention of Latinos), and those who fit neither of these two primary modes (e.g., other respondents who see themselves as only American or only wrote down cultural references).

Examples of responses that were coded as singular identities include: “Latino, Hispanic, Mexican-American;” “I consider myself South American;” “Spanish ancestry;” and “Cuban, Caribbean.” Responses coded as dual ethnoracial identities include: “Hispanic Indian from Mexico;” “White, with Latin American heritage;” “Mixed (Latino & White);” and “I identify as Afrolatina, African-American, and Hispanic.” Responses coded as other (not fitting either of the two modes) include: “American;” “Hard working, ambitious, family oriented, Catholic;” and “My skin color.”⁹

The second survey included questions to assess the importance of ethnoracial identities to Latinos’ broader sense of self. Because perceived membership in a category does not necessarily reveal its centrality, I employ questions capturing identity salience (McClain et al. 2009). Respondents are asked to rank their selected racial self-classification in a Census-style question against their national origin, Latino, and American identities. Respondents’ racial self-classifications and panethnic label preferences are piped in such that a question might read: “How important are being White, Hispanic, Puerto Rican, and American to your identity? Rank them in order of importance.”

Modeling Approach

I use random forests – an approach that is less susceptible to overfitting and more flexibly accounts for complex interactions – to examine the predictors of open-ended identities and identity prioritization (Montgomery and Olivella 2018). This method outperforms OLS in prediction and is ideal for clarifying intricate social processes related to ethnoracial identity selection. Because random forests do not produce conventional coefficient estimates, I rely upon permutation variable importance measures (VIMs) and partial dependence plots (Wei, Lu, and Song 2015). A predictor that scores high on variable importance is particularly useful for minimizing mean-squared error, and a predictor that scores low is not very helpful to the model in predicting the outcome. After determining which variables explain the most variation in the outcome, partial dependence plots examine the direction and magnitude of the marginal relationship (see Appendix A for more details).

Key predictors are generational status, income, education, national origin binaries,¹⁰ and reflected race, a proxy for phenotype in the absence of interviewer ratings in an online survey (López et al. 2018).¹¹ The reflected race question asks, “How would most people describe you, if, for example, they walked past you on the street? Would they say you are ...” The response options include “Black,” “White,” “Latino,” “Mixed race or multiracial,” “Asian,” and “Other,” and I code a binary variable for respondents who think others racialize them as Latinx versus anything else. While reflected race does not always align with racialization by others (Roth 2016), self-reported skin tone faces similar issues (Ostfeld and Yadon 2022). More “objective” measures of racialization by others – like interviewer ratings – themselves only represent one context or observer, whereas respondents’ own answers may reflect their day-to-day racialization in spaces they inhabit, incorporating non-phenotypic markers like accents. Finally, the models include other social and demographic covariates that may be endogenous to ethnoracial identity choices (Davenport 2016; Egan 2020; García 2017): gender, age, citizenship status, language, party ID, and non-Latinx

parentage.¹²

Results

Descriptives: Two modes of Ethnoracial Identities

How do Latinos perceive their ethnoracial group memberships in open-ended terms? Table 1 presents the distribution of the two primary identity modes using the coded attributes from the open-ended question. The table presents subcategories for whether respondents mention only non-Latinx ethnoracial groups, non-Latinx ethnoracial groups in combination with something else, only panethnicity, only national origin, or both; the “other” category only includes individuals who do not fall into either of the two previous categories.¹³

A majority of respondents fall within the singular mode (53 percent), and respondents in this category use national origin labels somewhat more frequently than panethnic labels. Turning to dual ethnoracial identities, 36 percent of respondents understand themselves in ethnoracial terms beyond Latinidad. Among these respondents, over half only mention non-Latinx ethnoracial groups or labels, while a smaller number mention race in combination with other attributes. The remaining 11 percent of respondents who fall into the “Other” category mentioned only other attributes, such as their skin tone or cultural practices, or identified only as American. This could indicate unfamiliarity with ethnoracial identification or alternative strategies of blurring boundaries by deemphasizing race or stressing American identities (see Dowling 2015; Wimmer 2008).

Turning to question wording differences, Appendix Figure C1 demonstrates that individuals are less likely to express dual ethnoracial identities when asked to describe their racial identity to other Latinos. This finding is driven by an increase in the use of national origin labels in this condition, suggesting that it is a more salient differentiator within fully Latinx contexts. Respondents are also more likely to fall into the “Other” category in this

Mode of Ethnoracial Identity	Percent
Singular Latinx Identity	53
Panethnic	19
National Origin	30
Panethnic and National Origin	4
Dual Ethnoracial Identities	36
Non-Latinx Race Only	22
Non-Latinx Race and Another Identity	14
Other	11

Table 1: Distribution of Primary Modes of Ethnoracial Identity. This table presents the percentage of respondents classified into the primary modes of ethnoracial identification: a singular Latinx identity expressed in panethnic or national-origin terms, dual ethnoracial identities incorporating non-Latinx racial labels, or another form of identification. Nonresponses are excluded from the first-survey denominator (weighted $N = 679$). The 11 percent of respondents in the “Other” category identified only as American or mentioned only attributes that did not fall into the other categories. Respondents in this category did not mention racial, panethnic, or national-origin identities. Responses classified as panethnic or national origin may also include additional references, such as “Latino American.” Shares are weighted using entropy balancing.

condition; analysis of open-ends suggests that many individuals rely on cultural attributes or similarities when describing their identity to other Latinos that are not neatly categorized into either of the two modes. However, 30 percent of respondents express dual ethnoracial identities when asked to describe their racial identity to other Latinos, suggesting that these identities are still salient among Latinos.¹⁴

Next, to explore the extent to which these non-Latinx ethnoracial identities are meaningful vis-à-vis panethnicity, I turn to the identity prioritization measure, assessing the share of respondents who ranked their selected racial self-classification on a Census-style question – such as white, Black, Indigenous, or mixed race – as more important to their identity than the panethnic category. Overall, 33 percent of respondents rank their selected self-classification higher. Figure 1 shows that relative racial identity salience is highest among Black self-classifiers – nearly sixty percent ranked being Black as more important to their identity than being Latinx. Meanwhile, “Some other race” self-classifiers have the lowest rate – at under 20 percent – which suggests that this classification encompasses

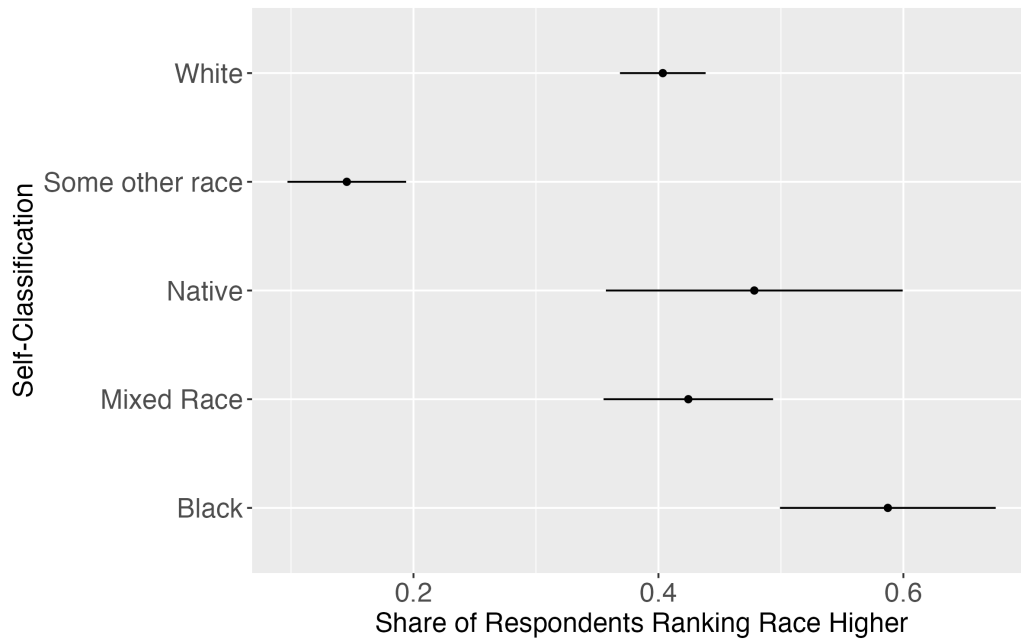


Figure 1: Share of Respondents Ranking Non-Latinx Ethnoracial Labels as More Important than Panethnicity by Self-Classification. This figure displays the share of respondents prioritizing their racial self-classifications above Latino or Hispanic panethnicity (on the x-axis) by their selected racial self-classification (on the y-axis). Respondents’ racial self-classifications and panethnic labels are piped in such that a question might read: “How important are being White, Hispanic, Puerto Rican, and American to your identity? Rank them in order of importance.” The labels on the y-axis are abbreviations and do not represent the exact categories presented to respondents on the Census-style question. Results draw from the second survey (N=1,488). Shares are weighted using entropy balancing.

those who primarily understand their race in singular panethnic terms.¹⁵ These findings lend further support to the idea that ethnoracial identities beyond Latinidad are not merely labels Latinos adopt given the ubiquity of Census self-classifications; they are also a salient aspect of many Latinos’ identities.

The third replication study allows for a comparison of the open-ended and ranking measures, which correlate moderately at $r=0.49$. Among those with a singular open-ended identity, 11 percent rank the racial labels they selected on a separate self-classification question as more important than panethnic labels. By contrast, among those in the dual category, 57 percent rank these other racial labels as more important to them. Thus, those in the singular mode express the strongest attachments to Latinidad, whereas – as the theory

suggests – those in the dual mode identify with labels such as Black or white but feel a range of attachment to these categories. Taken together, these findings indicate that the measures capture different dimensions of the same underlying theoretical construct of ethnoracial identity.

Predictors of Ethnoracial Identities: Random Forest Results

To evaluate core hypotheses on which social processes explain variation in identity selection and prioritization, Figure 2 presents the variable importance measures from two random forest models. The left panel presents the top predictors of open-ended identities in descending order, where the dependent variable is a multinomial variable for whether a respondent adopts primarily a singular Latinx identity, dual ethnoracial identities, neither of these modes, or nonresponse. On the right panel, the dependent variable is a binary for whether respondents rank their racial self-classification higher than their panethnicity. The x-axis presents the percent reduction in mean-squared error explained by a given variable, a measure of a variable's predictive value. VIMs measure predictive value rather than effect size or direction; VIMs below zero indicate that observed values of a given variable are less helpful to the model than randomizing them, reflecting poor predictive power.

The variable importance plots reveal that predictors are largely consistent across the two measures. Latinx parentage, racial self-classification, generation, and (to a lesser extent) Mexican origin emerge as the strongest predictors across both measures. For identity prioritization, reflected race explains the most variation in ranking one's racial self-classification above panethnicity. For the open-ended model, having two Latinx parents explains the greatest reduction in model error. Other national origin variables – such as being Cuban, Puerto Rican, or Salvadoran – are consistently weaker predictors of identity choices, though identifying Spanish ancestry is an exception for identity prioritization. Interestingly, income and education are the least predictive variables of identity prioritization. The variable importance is negative, which means that knowing an individual's SES

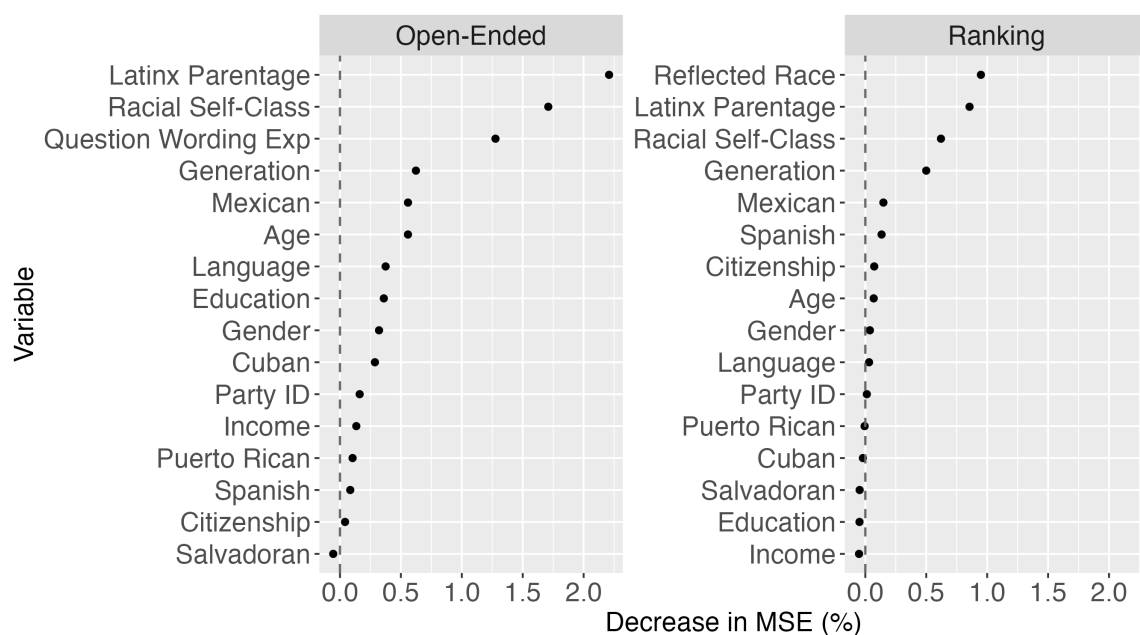


Figure 2: Most Predictive Variables of Ethnoracial Identities from Random Forests. This figure plots predictors (on the y-axis) in descending order by their variable importance (on the x-axis) from random forest models. On the left panel, the dependent variable is the multinomial open-ended ethnoracial identity variable, with possible values being dual, singular, other, or missing. On the right panel, the dependent variable is the binary ranking variable for whether a respondent prioritizes non-Latinx ethnoracial labels above panethnicity or not. The VIMs are averaged across 100 iterations of the random forests due to their stochastic nature. The decrease in MSE indicates the predictive power of each variable. Values close to or below zero do no better than chance in explaining the DVs. Note that national origin binaries are included for the largest four national origin groups (Mexicans, Puerto Ricans, Cubans, and Salvadorans) along with Spanish ancestry because respondents expressed their national origin through both their parents, and many respondents are of multiple national origins.

is actually less useful for predicting identity prioritization than choosing random values by chance. Education is somewhat predictive of open-ended identity choices but explains less than a third of the variation of the strongest predictor. These findings suggest a limited role of socioeconomic status and national origin beyond Mexican origin in explaining ethnoracial identity choices.¹⁶

Because the variable importance measures do not indicate the magnitude and direction of the marginal relationships between identity and these variables, I generate partial dependence plots of predicted values holding constant other variables. Figure 3 displays these predicted values for reflected race on the x-axis and prioritizing non-Latinx ethno-

racial identities on the y-axis. Individuals who state that others racially perceive them as something other than Latinx (e.g., white, Black, etc.) are about 15 percentage points more likely to prioritize non-Latinx ethnoracial identities, indicating strong support for H1. The model predicts nearly half of these individuals to prioritize other ethnoracial labels, holding constant all other factors like ancestry or national origin.¹⁷

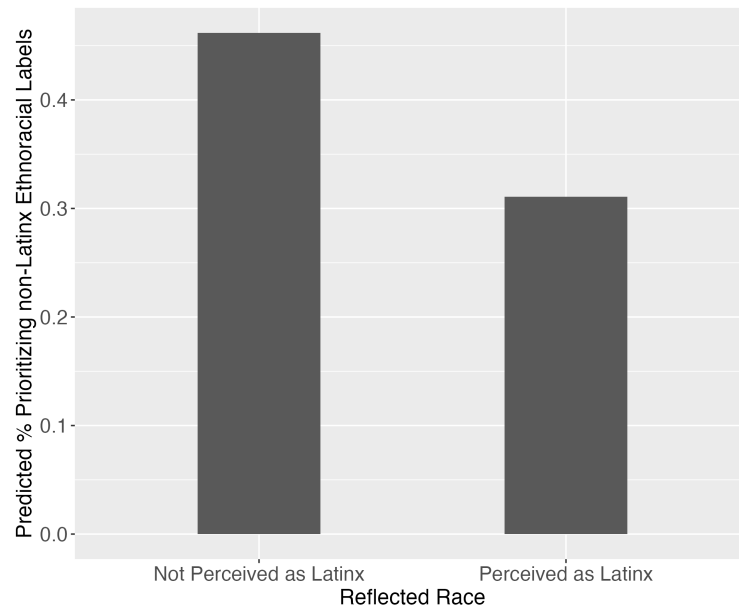


Figure 3: Partial Dependence Plot of Reflected Race and Ethnoracial Identity Prioritization. This figure plots the marginal relationship (partial dependence) between reflected race and the likelihood of ranking non-Latinx ethnoracial labels above panethnicity. The x-axis displays the reflected race binary variable, Latinx or not Latinx (recall that respondents who reported they are perceived as something other than Latinx, e.g., white or Black, are recoded into this binary). The y-axis displays the predicted share of respondents ranking the non-Latinx labels above panethnicity, holding all other variables constant. Results apply entropy weights.

Turning to socioeconomic status, Appendix Figures D2 and D3 indicate limited support for any relationship with ethnoracial identity decisions (H2a and H2b). Consistent with H2a, there is some evidence that college-educated respondents are more likely to express awareness of dual ethnoracial identities, but identity prioritization is around the same across education levels. Likewise, while those with the highest incomes are somewhat more likely to express dual identities or prioritize non-Latinx ethnoracial identities, this finding should be discounted by the near-zero predictive power of income across both measures in

the variable importance. Because the VIMs consider variables that are useful to the model through interactions, this finding suggests that SES does little to explain identity decisions.

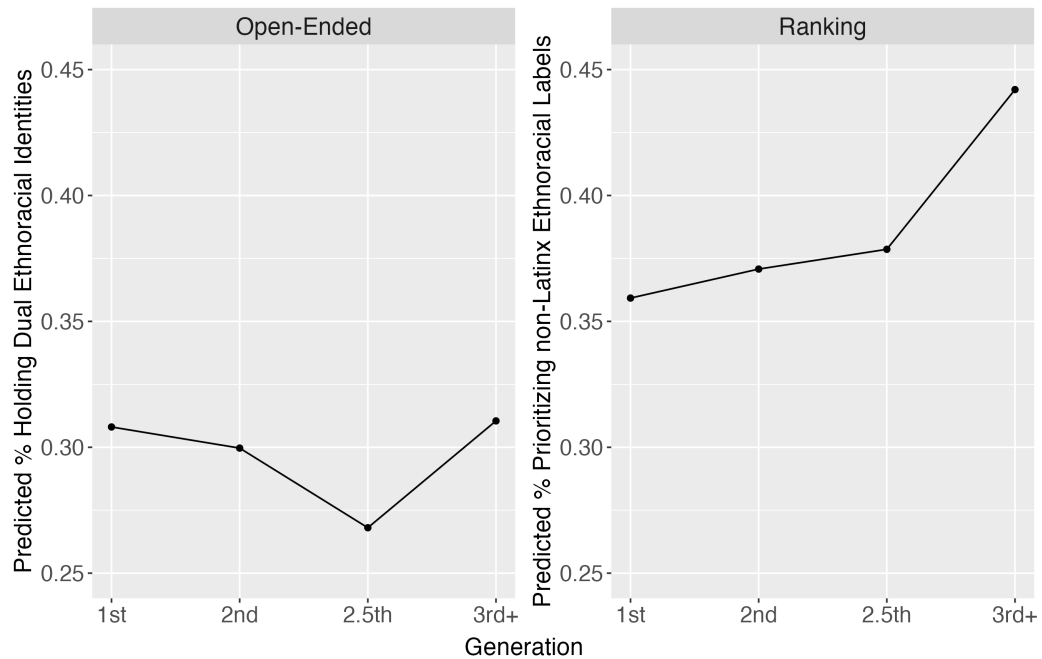


Figure 4: Partial Dependence Plot of Generation and Open-Ended Identities & Identity Prioritization. This figure plots the marginal relationship (partial dependence) between immigrant generation and ethnoracial identities. The x-axis includes marks for the 1st (foreign-born to foreign parents), 2nd (native-born to foreign parents), 2.5 (native-born to one foreign-born parent), and 3rd+ (native-born to native parents) generations. The y-axis displays the predicted share of respondents holding dual ethnoracial identities (left panel) or ranking the non-Latinx labels above panethnicity (right panel), holding all other variables constant. Results apply entropy weights.

Immigrant generation has a notably nonlinear relationship with ethnoracial identity decisions, evincing support for both H3a and H3b. Figure 4 shows that, for open-ended identities, the first and third generations are the most likely to hold dual ethnoracial identities, while the second generation – particularly the 2.5 generation – is least likely to do so. For identity prioritization, the relationship is monotonically increasing but sharply higher among the 3rd+ generation, who are around 8 percentage points more likely to prioritize other ethnoracial identities. These findings suggest that – although first and third generation respondents adopt dual identities at similar rates – these identities are most meaningful among the third generation, for whom Latinx ties may be weaker.

Finally, Figure 5 displays the marginal relationships for Mexican and Spanish national origin binaries, the two national origins among the top predictors of identity decisions. Results are consistent with H4 for these groups, though other national origins had little predictive power. Mexican respondents are more likely to possess a singular identity, while Spanish respondents are more likely to rank other racial labels above panethnicity.

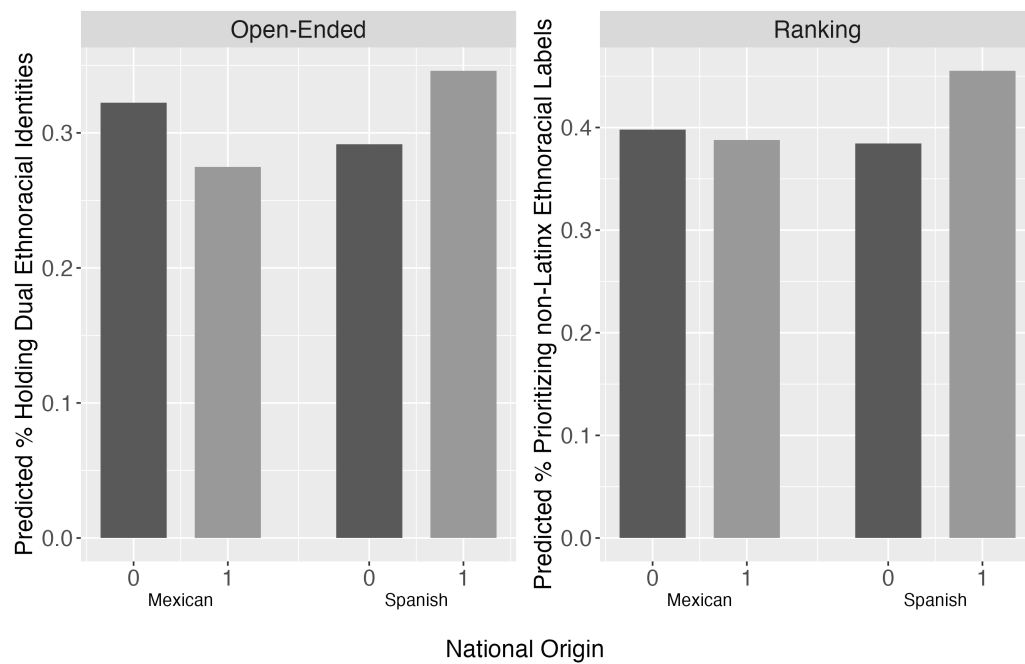


Figure 5: Partial Dependence Plot of Mexican and Spanish National Origin, Open-Ended Identities & Identity Prioritization. This figure plots the marginal relationship (partial dependence) between Mexican and Spanish national origin and ethnoracial identities. As respondents could report more than one national origin, these national origins are binaries and not mutually exclusive. The y-axis displays the predicted share of respondents holding dual ethnoracial identities (left panel) or ranking the non-Latinx labels above panethnicity (right panel), holding all other variables constant. Results apply entropy weights.

Qualitative Evidence: Exploring Mechanisms

The in-depth interviews illuminate the relationships between racialization, generation, SES, and identity choices, as well as the meanings behind the racial labels individuals adopt. For respondents who identified as both white and Latinx, whiteness was often not a personally meaningful identity but was nonetheless seen as consequential for daily life. Many

of these respondents discussed being treated differently than siblings or family members who are not light-skinned or being assumed to be non-Latinx by other Latinos. In a few cases, whiteness was associated with negative attitudes toward Latinos or other ethnoracial groups. For example, Katelyn – a 29-year-old stay-at-home parent who grew up in Brazil and moved to Ohio in her 20s – identifies as white, rejecting any notion of white privilege and describing an incident in which she felt profiled when she visited New Orleans:

“I remember a bunch of Black girls looking so bad to me and my friends. I felt almost scared how they looked at us, and I knew it was because we were lighter. I knew that. That kinda blows my mind because I was like you are judging me because I’m lighter, but you don’t know I’m Latina, I’m from Brazil . . . And that night, we didn’t see much other people like us around, so I think that’s what it was.”

Afro-Latinx interviewees also tied their identities to racialization, although they often described these identities as a source of pride. Many Afro-Latinos detailed coming to terms with their identity because their parents had not discussed it growing up. Both education and age appear to play a role, as younger, more formally educated Afro-Latinos described embracing their Blackness during schooling. For example, Maria is a 25-year-old Dominican American social worker who was born and raised in New York City. She described wanting to be lighter-skinned growing up and not getting along with Black women, but this changed during her postgraduate degree:

“I was in the social work profession, and my classrooms were mostly Black and Brown women, Hispanic and Black . . . so you start bouncing off ideas, and social work is a lot of discussions about racial issues, socioeconomic issues . . . It also made me feel part of the community, because I was in a room full of professionals, Black and Brown people, and we were basically demonstrating what Black excellence is.”

For other respondents, both education and racialization by others play a role in fostering a strong singular ethnoracial identity as Latinx. William is a 43-year-old Mexican American school administrator with a postgraduate education from Colorado. When asked

to describe his race, he says:

“I always tell them I’m Mexican American ... When they talk about race, I refuse to put white on my documents. I always put “Other” because I’m not white, and that’s just another way our government has labeled and took advantage of us. I don’t get the white privileges . . . I’m a politically minded Chicano because I believe in what the movement did.”

While he is of the 2.5 generation (having one Mexican American and one Mexican-born parent), his awareness of Chicano activism shapes the strength of his Latinx identity. Later, when I asked about how others tend to racially identify him, he described how racialization as Mexican constrains his identity:

“Oh, as Mexican. I mean, we were at a store, and they asked me if I knew Spanish or English. No, it’s like, I speak perfect English, do you? Again, I think my physical appearance gives it away . . . I’m a big old brown dude, bro. And I’m dark, I’m not light skinned . . . so yeah, they know I’m Mexican.”

William and Maria’s experiences reveal how higher SES may encourage a strong singular ethnoracial identity for some and dual identities for others. John, a 26-year-old teacher from San Diego, also exemplifies this tension. His parents are both lawyers, and whereas his Mexican American mother emphasized Latinx activism growing up, his Native American father encouraged an appreciation for Ho-Chunk traditions. Thus, while John notes that others often perceive him to be white, this is not an identity he has ever held closely.

The interviewees mentioned above were quite stable in their sense of ethnoracial identity, but other respondents expressed more uncertainty. This fluidity was often tied to being ambiguously racialized by others, particularly in specific ethnoracial contexts. For example, Sebastian is a 21-year-old Colombian American college student in the Bay Area from a majority Latinx community in New Jersey. He explained that his Latino identity was never questioned on the East Coast, but in California he is often asked if he is Black. Now, he identifies as mixed race or Afro-Latinx but with some hesitation, as he does not feel like he

was raised with African American culture. Another such respondent is Albert, a 48-year-old Mexican American with some college education from the Chicago area who moved to the U.S. when he was 13. He describes the changing nature of his racial identity:

“Well, to me it’s interesting because it’s always changing. I used to think I’m more of a Native American ... But when I started doing more research, I’m like, wait a minute. I’m not Indian at all – I’m mostly from the Northern part of Spain, from the Basque region. Almost 100% of my ancestors come from that region . . . so now, I think of myself as mostly Spanish because I kind of have to accept it . . . that’s what I am, at least ethnically.”

Albert went on to express some uncertainty over how others perceive his race; he noted that people are sometimes surprised to learn he was born in Mexico.

Finally, Indigenous identities emerged as a unique category. One respondent noted that she only began to identify as Indigenous following genetic ancestry testing. While racialization does appear to play a role, this identity is more closely linked to cultural or ancestral connections. For example, Diana is a 29-year-old resident obstetrician who identifies as Mixtec and grew up as a farm worker in Eastern Oregon. She notes that other Latinos would make negative comments about her family having dark skin or being shorter. Whereas her mother emphasized their family’s Mixtec origins growing up, she didn’t embrace this identity until she was older:

“I started more confidently being able to say I’m Indigenous from Oaxaca ... I feel like it’s a strength because it’s so many generations of our family living in our village and being able to survive ... I think it would also be very easy to forget where I come from ... There’s very little things that – except for the food, my mom, and her stories – once she is not telling us those things anymore, I don’t know that necessarily we’d be like, ‘oh, we’re Mixteco, we’re Oaxacan.’ ”

This quote reveals how Diana’s Indigenous identity is closely tied to her connection to her mother’s pueblo. Although education likely shaped her eventual acceptance of her identity as Mixtec, her mother always identified as such and stressed the importance of their heritage.

Discussion

Latinos now make up about one in five individuals in the U.S., but we lack a comprehensive framework to explain the different ways in which they identify their race. Past work has been limited in part by a focus on ethnoracial self-classifications, which may not accurately reflect one's open-ended identity. While closely attending to the legacy of racialization and mobilization fostering strong panethnic identities, the literature has often paid less attention to indicators of ethnoracial difference and disunity. This is despite the history of Latin America being marked by the enslavement of African and Indigenous people, colonization, and large waves of immigration, and the persistence of race and color inequalities both in Latin America and among U.S. Latinos.

In this paper, I endeavor to fill this gap by advancing a novel framework to assess why some Latinos understand their race through the lens of *Latinidad* and why others adopt additional ethnoracial identities. Drawing upon three original surveys, I show that while a majority of Latinos identify primarily with panethnicity or national origin, a third utilize other ethnoracial labels such as Afro-Latino, white, or Indigenous. Random forest models – which allow predictors to interact with each other without prespecified interaction terms or functional form assumptions – reveal that respondents who are first or third generation are most likely to identify with these additional ethnoracial labels. SES and national origin, in contrast to a wide body of comparative work in Latin America, less strongly predict this choice.

By showing that the relationship between immigrant generation and identity is non-linear, the findings suggest that proximity to Latin American ethnoracial schemas among the first generation and distance from the immigrant experience among the third-plus generation may *both* predict identity choices. Put differently, the first generation may possess an awareness of labels like white, Black, or Indigenous due to their growing prominence in

Latin America, whereas the third generation may be aware of these labels in the context of U.S. racial schemas. Second-generation Latinos, meanwhile, may be most likely to adopt singular panethnic identities because they retain stronger Latinx ties than the third generation but are removed from Latin American schemas. This may also explain why many national origin groups like Cubans, Puerto Ricans, and Salvadorans did not emerge as important predictors of identity, in contrast to prior work (Telles and Flores 2013; Irizarry et al. 2022), as it may be through immigrant generation that proximity to certain national ideologies (e.g., whiteness in Argentina) matters. Nevertheless, findings on the importance of Mexican and Spanish national origins are consistent with the unique historical racialization of Mexican Americans and the ethnoracial meanings behind the “Spanish” label (Dowling 2015; Salgado 2020). Because these mechanisms are suggestive, future work would do well to empirically examine how the specific meanings attached to labels like Afro-Latinx vary by generation.

The findings also clarify the intricate relationship between SES, racialization, and identity. The interviews contextualize the weak and inconsistent relationship between SES and ethnoracial identity in the random forests. Higher SES may reinforce a singular ethnoracial identity for some – for example, through the rejection of whiteness – while heightening awareness of intra-Latinx racial difference for others. Quantitative findings demonstrate that racialization by others continues to play a crucial constraining role in ethnoracial identity selection, but it is one of several factors in this process. As the interviews show, local ethnoracial context (e.g., in New York versus San Francisco) nuances this relationship. Racialization is less clearly tied to identities like Native or Indigenous, which are often cultural, tribal, and at times genetic ancestry claims. Future research would do well to explore Indigenous identity among Latinos and the extent to which it is linked with immigration, SES, or the rise in genetic ancestry testing (Nagel 1995; Roth and Ivermark 2018).

Latinos’ ethnoracial identities may be important indicators of boundary shifts. Many

Latinos – by asserting dual identities as white and Latinx – may be challenging existing understandings of race that position whiteness as mutually exclusive from Latinidad and potentially expanding the range of phenotypes accepted as white. Likewise, many Black and Indigenous-identifying Latinos recognize their distinct racializations and contest ethnoracial hierarchies through their identities. As boundary shifts ultimately depend on dominant group perceptions (Abascal 2020), future work may address the extent to which non-Latinx white people loosen the boundaries of whiteness to include individuals of certain phenotypes with Latinx names (Schachter, Flores, and Maghbouleh 2021).

While the focus of this work has been Latinos, this framework might help us understand the identities of other groups who navigate blurry, overlapping boundaries. For example, as MENA and multiracial Americans continue to grow in population and become established in the U.S., individuals in these groups may face similar trade-offs of expanding whiteness or rejecting it (Davenport 2016; cf. Maghbouleh, Schachter, and Flores 2022). Outside the U.S., the identities of marginalized groups in Europe may be understood through this paradigm of multiple ethnoracial options. Muslim women in France, for example, respond to state exclusion by strengthening both French and Muslim identities (Abdelgadir and Fouka 2020), whereas phenotypic proximity to natives among some North African and Turkish immigrants in Europe may provide leeway for attempts at boundary expansion (Alba 2005).

These findings also have implications for considerations around a combined or separate race and Latinx origin Census question. Compared to studies that examine self-classifications in a combined question – which find that around 70 to 74 percent of Latinos select only a Latinx racial self-classification (Campbell and Rogalin 2006; Flores, Telles, and Ventura 2024) – the present findings suggest that some of these respondents may express additional ethnoracial labels in open-ended terms. This is consistent with work by Flores, Telles, and Ventura (2024) showing that a combined question may decrease Black

or Indigenous self-classifications among Latinos. As Telles (2018) suggests, the combined question – while recognizing Latinx as an important racial category and identity – poorly captures additional dimensions of race for Latinos. The empirical approach taken here presents an alternative for researchers seeking to measure Latinx ethnoracial identities. Open-ended questions that allow respondents to describe their identities in greater depth may better capture these additional dimensions of race, while the identity prioritization measure evinces their relative importance to the self compared with panethnicity.

In addition to centering the often-overlooked experiences of Indigenous and Afro-Latinos, scholars should pay close attention to the social and political implications of these identities. A growing body of work documents how white and Black identities among Latinos are intricately tied to racialized political attitudes or linked fate with Black people (Cleland and Gutierrez 2025; Filindra and Kolbe 2022). How might prioritizing a Black or white identity vis-à-vis Latinidad explain attitudes on issues like immigration or affirmative action? As Latinos continue to grow as a share of the U.S. population, it will be important to understand how their identity claims contest or reinforce existing racial hierarchies. Scholarship on Latinos should remain attentive to intra-group difference and identify important points of panethnic unity and disunity.

Notes

1. For readability, I use “Latinx” and “Latinos” as the singular and plural forms, respectively, to encompass individuals in the U.S. of both Hispanic and Latino descent. “Latinidad” is the Spanish noun for being Latino, analogous to Blackness or whiteness.
2. For example, the League of United Latin American Citizens (LULAC) – the oldest Latinx civil rights organization in the U.S. – successfully countered school segregation by arguing that while it was permissible for Black children under *Plessy v. Ferguson*, Mexican Americans were white and entitled to the same facilities as white children.
3. I focus on the results from the first two surveys but reference the third replication study where needed.
4. See Appendix A. In short, the first survey included only respondents who self-classify as Latinx, while the second and third included a minority of respondents who did not do so but reported Latinx ancestry through at least one grandparent.
5. The third survey was available in both English and Spanish, but only 0.7 percent of respondents took it in Spanish.
6. See Appendix A on nonprobability sampling and weights.
7. Respondents’ preferences for Hispanic or Latino as panethnic terms were piped in. The two question versions assess how context shapes ethnoracial identity decisions. As this experiment is not central to the present study, I report its results in Appendix C.
8. I thank an anonymous reviewer for clarifying this point. In the replication study, I varied whether respondents receive the “Please list a few things that come to mind”

instructions. Results – presented in Appendix Figure C2 – reveal that the substantive conclusions of the analysis are consistent regardless of prompt wording.

9. See Appendix A for more details on open-ended response coding.
10. National origins are coded as binaries because many respondents reported more than one national origin through their mother or father.
11. Reflected race was only queried in the second survey and, as such, is only included in the identity salience model.
12. Latinx parentage is an important variable, given the greater availability of other racial labels to Latinos with a non-Latinx parent. These individuals are a growing subpopulation given increasing intermarriage, though they may not always adopt multiple ethnoracial labels (see Davenport 2016, 2018).
13. By design, these categories are mutually exclusive. Note that while the singular ethnoracial identity category excludes non-Latinx ethnoracial mentions, it includes other mentions like American identities or cultural references alongside panethnic mentions.
14. Appendix Figure C2 shows that respondents are significantly more likely to express singular ethnoracial identities when not prompted to “list a few things.” This suggests that these instructions encouraged some respondents who would otherwise identify as only Latinx to disclose additional racial labels. However, as 37 percent of respondents express dual ethnoracial identities without this prompt, substantive conclusions remain the same.
15. “Some other race” self-classifiers were prompted to choose an option that was not “Some other race” earlier in the survey, and this question pipes in that response.
16. In Appendix Figure D4, I explore which variables explain “Other” respondents in particular. The top predictor is the question wording experiment; this aligns with

earlier findings that “Other” responses are much higher in the condition in which respondents were asked to describe their identity to other Latinos because respondents often mentioned cultural attributes or similarities. Age and generation are other top predictors. The marginal relationships suggest that older, first-generation respondents may be most likely to reject ethnoracial identification or express uncertainty with this process.

17. In Appendix Figure D1, I show that having a non-Latinx parent similarly predicts around a 15 percent increase in holding dual ethnoracial identities. Respondents with only a Latinx mother are slightly more likely to adopt dual ethnoracial identities, which aligns with work on multiracial individuals finding that surnames passed on through the father may affect ethnoracial identities (Davenport 2016).

Data Availability

Survey data underlying this article, as well as replication code to produce figures and tables, are available in the Harvard Dataverse, at <https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataverse/limits-of-panethnicity/>. Interview transcripts are available upon request.

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Appendix

Appendix A: Additional Details on Survey Data and Methods

Data and Sample Characteristics: I conducted three online surveys through Cint managed research and Cloud Research Connect in June/July 2023 (N=733), April 2024 (N=1,488), and March 2026 (N=577). In the first survey, respondents were recruited into the sample with the Census Hispanic/Latino ethnicity question: “Are you of Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish origin?” Respondents who said “No, not of Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish origin” were removed from the sample. Because I use Latinx to refer to both Hispanic and Latinx individuals, I include respondents who identify their national origin as solely Spanish or Spaniard. This also ensures the inclusion of many *nuevomexicanos* and other Latinx individuals whose families have resided in the Southwest since before the Mexican-American War and who may identify primarily as Spanish (Salgado 2020).

In order to account for the possibility of ethnic attrition (Duncan and Trejo 2011), respondents in the second and third surveys were kept in the sample if they did not self-classify as Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish but said they had at least one Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish grandparent. However, in practice, only 1-2 percent of the samples did not self-classify as Latinx but reported Latinx ancestry. This is likely an underestimate of attriters and a result of the survey vendor targeting respondents who at one point self-classified as Hispanic or Latino. Garnering more respondents with Latinx ancestry but who do not self-classify as Hispanic or Latinx would require a more expensive sample, as survey vendors base their rates on having a high enough incidence rate – e.g., retaining respondents who are sent to the survey. I would therefore have to target respondents of all ethnoracial backgrounds and remove those who do not report Latinx ancestry, a very costly approach. Thus, as noted in the main text, the identities of those with Hispanic or Latinx ancestry who exit the panethnic category are beyond the scope of the data. However, the

two primary identity modes advanced above describe the overwhelming majority of Latinos who continue to identify quite strongly with Latinidad or with national origin groups in the third generation and beyond, even as a nontrivial share cease to identify as Latinx.

Researchers have raised concerns about the quality of data attained through convenience samples (MacInnis et al. 2018). A recent review (Stagnaro et al. 2026) notes that not all nonprobability samples are equal and finds a tradeoff between attentiveness and representativeness in online surveys. In their study, CloudResearch Connect scored among the highest for response validity. Lucid / Cint perform worse on attentiveness but best on representativeness, and they suggest that issues with attention can be ameliorated with attention checks. In keeping with these recommendations, all surveys removed respondents who did not pass two initial attention checks. Post-screening attention checks revealed that high shares of respondents remained fully attentive. 61.4%, 74.9%, and 99.7% of respondents passed both of the post-screening attention checks on Surveys 1, 2, and 3, respectively. The share of respondents remaining mostly attentive – passing one or two of the post-screening attention checks – is higher, at 90.5%, 96.2%, and 100%, respectively. Respondents who failed attention checks do not appear to be speeding or giving unusual or random answers.

Table A1 below displays descriptive characteristics for the three surveys, before and after survey weights, compared to benchmarks drawn from the American Community Survey, Pew Research, and the American National Election Study. As noted in the data and methods section, I apply entropy weights (Hainmueller 2012) matched to the 2024 Current Population Survey to correct for important imbalances along the lines of immigrant generation and education, common among online opt-in samples. Table A1 reveals that entropy weights successfully improve imbalances across several variables, both those used for the weights (age, gender, region, education, and nativity) and others. Weighted samples closely match population or probability sample benchmarks by age, gender, region, generation, Latinx parentage, education, and partisanship. Mexican individuals are slightly

underrepresented – and weights decrease their share – but this might be useful for covering smaller national origin groups that may be underrepresented in the data. Another exception is Latinx parentage in the third replication survey, for which individuals with a non-Latinx parent remain overrepresented even after the addition of weights.

While entropy weights offer advantages over simple poststratification weights or propensity weighting, there are limits to the effectiveness of weights among nonprobability samples (MacInnis et al. 2018; Miratrix et al. 2018). As I note in the data and methods section, particular care must be taken in interpreting descriptive statistics and relationships, even though experimental results may generalize well (Jerit and Barabas 2023). Accordingly, descriptive statistics on the distribution of ethnoracial identity modes should neither be taken as precise nor representative of population-level statistics, and, rather, as suggestive evidence of the framework and variation in ethnoracial identity modes.

Table A1: Survey Characteristics

Survey	1	1	2	2	3	3	Benchmark
Weights	X	✓	X	✓	X	✓	
Median Age	33	41	40	41	33	41	41
% Women	53.2	51.4	54.4	51.4	51.0	51.4	51.4
% CA, TX, NY, FL	55.1	54.2	55.3	58.0	59.3	55.1	58.2
% Mexican	52.3	46.0	50.8	46.4	53.2	41.5	61.6
% in Spanish	0	0	9.0	20.8	0.7	5.1	—
% 1st Gen	12.3	46.7	18.1	49.5	12.3	50.7	42
% 3rd+ Gen	38.9	24.5	44.1	28.4	30.8	18.3	24
% 2 Latinx Parents	73.6	82.6	70.6	78.4	62.2	66.4	85
% Citizens	95.9	91.5	92.0	78.2	97.2	89.1	79
% Bachelor's+	33.4	20.7	34.3	20.7	43.5	20.7	21
% Democrat	56.2	55.3	51.6	48.8	59.4	51.4	57.5

Random Forests: Random forests are an ensemble machine-learning method that – in ad-

dition to accounting for overfitting – does not impose a functional form on the data. This is particularly useful for understanding ethnoracial identities, as it takes into consideration potential nonlinearities and complex interactions inherent to social identity processes. A random forest can leverage interactions unknown to the researcher to enhance predictive power without prespecifying them (Montgomery and Olivella 2018). Unlike OLS and LASSO, random forests do not produce conventional coefficient estimates for a marginal relationship between the independent and dependent variables. Instead, I rely upon permutation variable importance measures (VIMs) which permute– or randomly shuffle– the values of each predictor in a random forest model and subsequently calculate the decrease in mean-squared error (MSE) when the values of the given variable are permuted versus when they are at their true values (Wei, Lu, and Song 2015). The VIMs indicate which variables – from a host of social and demographic predictors – explain the most variation in ethnoracial identity selection. After narrowing down important predictors with VIMs, partial dependence plots generate predicted values to discern the marginal relationship between a predictor and the DV, net of all other variables.

Open-ended Response Coding: This subsection describes additional details on open-ended response coding in the first survey (N=733). As discussed in the methods section, respondents were asked two versions of an open-ended ethnoracial identity question: “How do you racially identify? Please list a few things that come to mind for you” or “How would you identify your race to other [Hispanic or Latino] people? Please list a few things that come to mind for you,” depending on the treatment groups to which respondents were randomly assigned. Distributions for each version of the question are displayed in Figure C1.

Responses were generally a short phrase and no longer than a sentence or two. To code the responses, I first read through each response (blind to treatment group assignment) and identified patterns. Ethnoracial, national origin, and American identities emerged as

most prevalent, so I went back and coded responses that mentioned these. Race mentions consisted almost entirely of “racial” labels, but I included a few respondents who mentioned non-Latinx national origins such as Russian and references to Spain specifically. Responses coded as mentioning panethnicity included the terms Hispanic, Latino, Spanish, Latin American, or combinations such as Afro-Latino. American mentions include those who wrote “American” on its own, as well as those who used a hyphenated term such as Hispanic / Latinx / Mexican American. Responses coded for “Other” attributes consisted of cultural mentions like food or language, mentions of similarities or differences to other Latinos, mentions of skin tone, other words not readily captured by other attributes like “diverse,” or uncertainty around or a normative rejection of race. Importantly, respondents were only assigned “Other” if their response was interpretable; some responses were too vague to be classified as anything, and these were counted as nonresponse.

Appendix B: Additional Details on Interviews

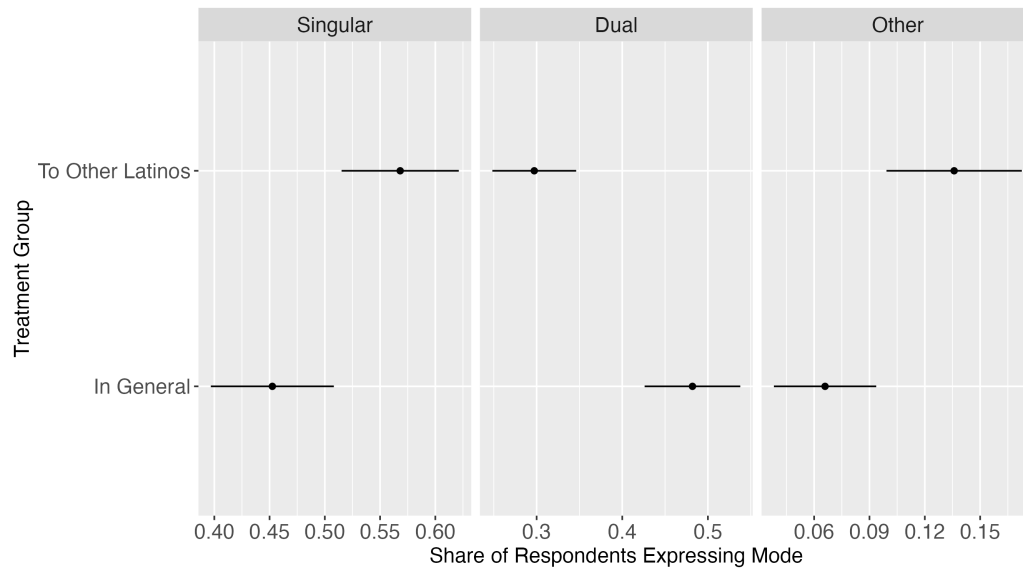
Interviews were conducted between May 2023 and June 2025. 16 out of the 29 interviewees (55%) identified their race primarily in panethnic or national origin terms, while the remaining 13 (45%) identified with additional ethnoracial terms. Most interviewees (23/29) were recruited through an online screening survey circulated through personal networks, social media, a few email lists (a Latinx university list and a college access program), and snowball sampling from these. The remaining respondents (6/29) were recruited after indicating interest to be interviewed at the end of the first Cint / Cloud Research Connect survey to ensure respondents beyond a few degrees of personal networks were reached. The descriptive characteristics are as follows:

- Average age: 32.2 years
- Gender: 21 women, 8 men
- State of residence: CA - 11, NY - 3, TX - 3, FL - 2, CO - 2, IL - 2, NE - 2, CT - 1, MA - 1, PA - 1, OH - 1
- National origin (mother): Mexico - 14, Dominican Republic - 3, Puerto Rico - 3, Venezuela - 3, Panama - 2, Brazil - 1, Colombia - 1, Guatemala - 1, Uruguay - 1
- National origin (father): Mexico - 14, Dominican Republic - 3, Venezuela - 3, Colombia - 2, Puerto Rico - 2, Brazil - 1, Cuba - 1, Guatemala - 1, Panama - 1, non-Latino (Native American) - 1
- Legal status: Citizen - 24, Permanent Resident - 3, TPS - 1, Other - 1
- Immigrant generation: 1st - 12, 1.5 - 1, 2nd - 13, 2.5 - 2, 3rd - 1
- Education: High school - 2, Some college - 16, Bachelor's - 6, Postgraduate - 5
- Language of interview: English - 25, Spanish - 4

Appendix C: Question Wording Variations to Open-Ended Question

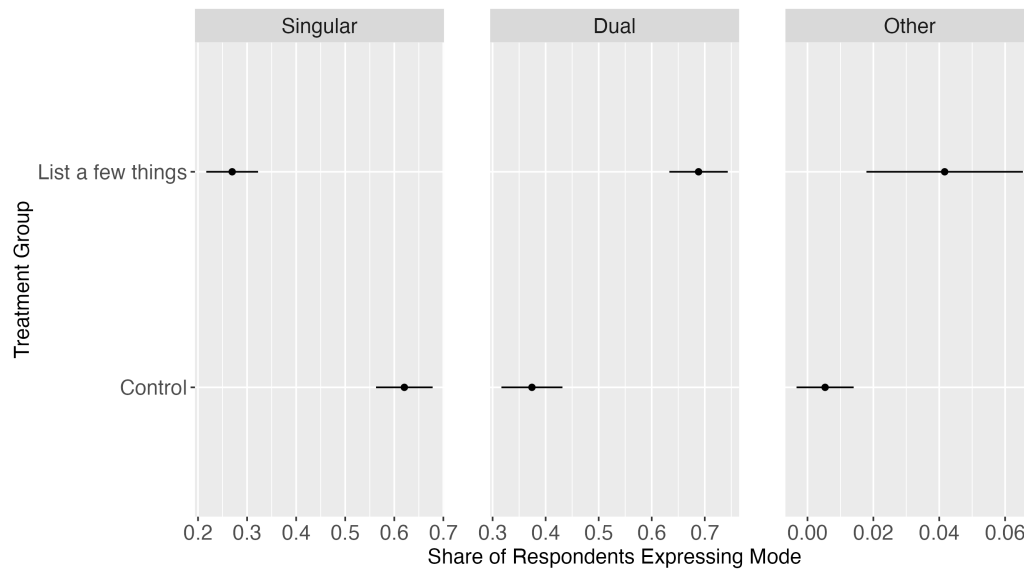
This appendix includes the results of question wording experiments on the open-ended ethnoracial identity question.

Figure C1: Effects of Question Wording on Ethnoracial Identity Distributions



Notes: This figure displays the results of the experiment assessing the effect of question wording on open-ended ethnoracial identity. The shares of respondents adopting a singular Latinx identity, dual ethnoracial identities, or neither of these (falling into the other category) are plotted on the x-axis. The y-axis plots estimates for respondents who were asked to describe their ethnoracial identity in general versus those who were asked to describe their ethnoracial identity to other Latinos, in keeping with the two versions of the question discussed in the methods section. Means are weighted using entropy balancing. Dual ethnoracial identities are much lower in the “to other Latinos” condition, which is largely driven by an increase in national origin labels.

Figure C2: Effect of “Please list a few things” Instructions on Ethnoracial Identity Distributions

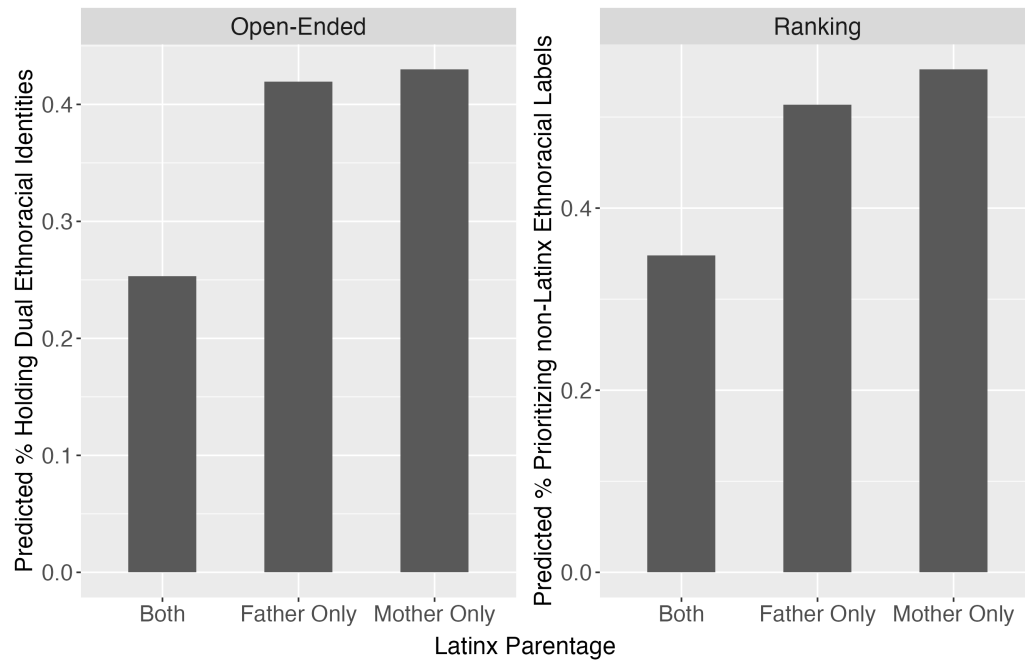


Notes: This figure displays the results of the experiment assessing the effect of the “Please list a few things that come to mind” instructions in the replication survey (N=577). The shares of respondents adopting a singular Latinx identity, dual ethnoracial identities, or neither of these (falling into the other category) are plotted on the x-axis. The y-axis plots estimates for the question, “How would you describe your racial identity?” with and without the additional instructions. Means are weighted using entropy balancing.

Appendix D: Additional Random Forest Results

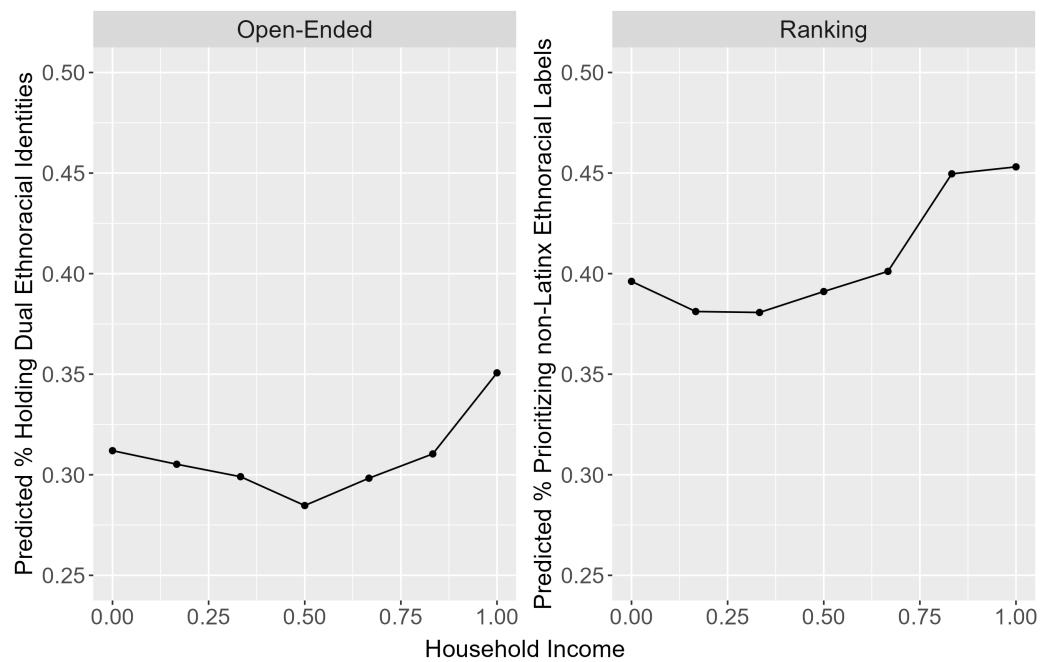
This appendix includes supplemental random forest results referenced in the main text.

Figure D1: Partial Dependence Plot of Latinx Parentage and Open-Ended Identities & Identity Prioritization



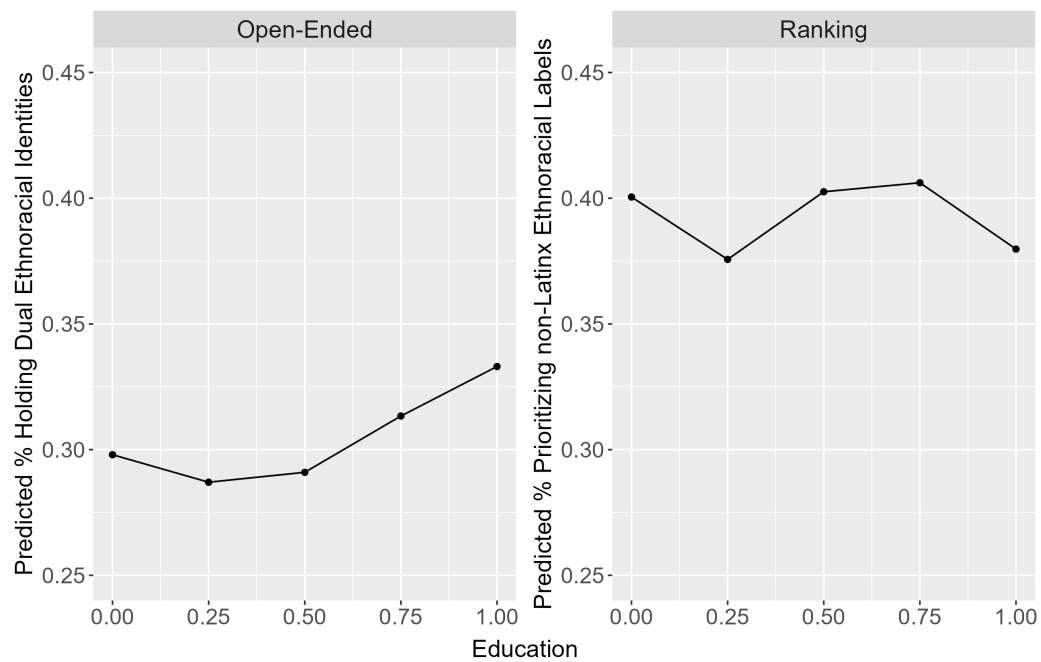
Notes: This figure plots the marginal relationship (partial dependence) between Latinx parentage and ethnoracial identities. The x-axis displays whether a respondent has two Latinx parents, only a Latinx father, or only a Latinx mother. The y-axis displays the predicted share of respondents holding dual ethnoracial identities (left panel) or ranking the non-Latinx labels above panethnicity (right panel), holding all other variables constant. Results apply entropy weights.

Figure D2: Marginal Relationship between Income and Open-Ended Identities & Identity Prioritization



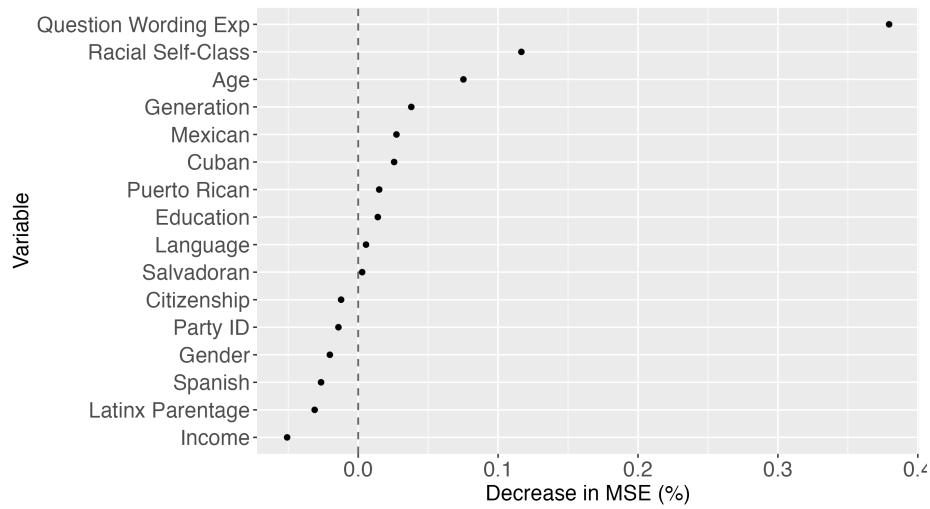
Notes: This figure plots the marginal relationship (partial dependence) between income and ethnoracial identities. The x-axis displays self-reported household income. The values, which originally range from \$0-\$24,999 to \$150,000 or more, are rescaled from 0 to 1. The y-axis displays the predicted share of respondents holding dual ethnoracial identities (left panel) or ranking the non-Latinx labels above panethnicity (right panel), holding all other variables constant. Results apply entropy weights.

Figure D3: Marginal Relationship between Education and Open-Ended Identities & Identity Prioritization



Notes: This figure plots the marginal relationship (partial dependence) between education and ethnoracial identities. The x-axis displays self-reported formal education. The values, which originally range from “Less than high school” to “Postgraduate degree,” are rescaled from 0 to 1. The y-axis displays the predicted share of respondents holding dual ethnoracial identities (left panel) or ranking the non-Latinx labels above panethnicity (right panel), holding all other variables constant. Results apply entropy weights.

Figure D4: Most Predictive Variables of “Other” Categorization from Random Forests



Notes: This figure plots predictors (on the y-axis) in descending order by their variable importance (on the x-axis) from a random forest model with a binary DV for whether respondents fell into the “Other” category. The VIMs are averaged across 100 iterations of the random forests due to their stochastic nature. The decrease in MSE indicates the predictive power of each variable. Values close to or below zero do no better than chance in explaining the DV. Note that national origin binaries are included for the largest four national origin groups (Mexicans, Puerto Ricans, Cubans, and Salvadorans) along with Spanish ancestry because respondents expressed their national origin through both their parents, and many respondents are of multiple national origins.